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Neurodiversity and academic integrity: toward epistemic plurality in a postplagiarism era

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ABSTRACT

Academic misconduct policies can disadvantage neurodivergent students through ableist assessment design, surveillance technologies, and pedagogies of forced disclosure. In this narrative review, the intersection of neurodiversity and academic integrity in higher education was examined by analyzing 15 sources, using postplagiarism as a conceptual framing. Three themes emerged: (1) neurodivergent students face intersectional challenges when academic integrity frameworks misinterpret their cognitive differences as misconduct indicators; (2) educational technologies present a double impact: AI can improve accessibility, but detection software produces false positives disproportionately affecting neurodivergent students; and (3) competitive assessment practices foster environments where misconduct becomes more likely. Epistemic plurality is proposed as a framework to reconceptualize academic integrity beyond punitive approaches. Rather than standardizing knowledge expression, we can recognize that diverse cognitive styles enrich, rather than compromise, academic quality. Academic integrity must evolve beyond compliance-based models toward inclusive approaches that honour neurodiversity as human variation that enriches academic communities.

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Introduction

We know relatively little about the relationship between academic integrity and neurodiversity. This paper is situated from a neurodiversity paradigm, grounded in social justice. drawing from Shaw et al.'s (2025) framing: 'Ontologically, the neurodiversity paradigm argues that neurodivergent people are different – not flawed, impaired, or disordered. Difference does not entail inherent lack of worth, regardless of whether difference is personally experienced as an impairment, a disability, or an advantage' (p. 2). Through this lens, I problematize current understandings of academic integrity as they are currently situated in research and practice as upholding academic norms and values that clash with a neurodiversity paradigm. I explore challenges and opportunities, concluding with a call to action for more holistic and inclusive approaches to academic

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integrity to support a neurodiverse student population. The examples I offer are intended to be illustrative, rather than exhaustive, serving as a point of departure for ongoing and deeper inquiry.

Neurodivergent students, including those with dyslexia, ADHD, Autism, and other learning differences, face unique challenges navigating academic integrity policies and practices. Although scholarship has examined academic integrity broadly, less attention has been paid to how neurodivergent students experience these policies and how institutions might better support them. Academic integrity policies and practices, particularly those focused on plagiarism detection, exam proctoring, and standardized assessment, can create substantial barriers for neurodivergent students. These barriers include heightened anxiety, difficulties with time management, challenges with writing and text production, and fear of stigmatization (Clouder et al. 2020). For example, text-matching software often used to detect plagiarism may flag the work of dyslexic students who rely on particular sentence structures or vocabulary to communicate their ideas (Kinder and Elander 2012). Such so-called academic integrity measures, when applied without nuance, can inadvertently disadvantage neurodivergent learners.

In this paper I explore the intersection of neurodiversity and academic integrity in higher education. Drawing on research in forensic linguistics, educational accessibility, and academic integrity, I argue that current approaches to academic integrity often disadvantage neurodivergent students through ableist assessment design, surveillance technologies, and pedagogies of forced disclosure.

Positionality statement

I am a qualitative researcher trained in both humanities and social sciences and so I begin by situating myself in terms of my identity and positionality. As a neurodivergent researcher with lived experience relevant to this study, I bring a perspective shaped both by personal insight and academic training. My position informs the questions I ask, the ways I interpret data, and the ethical considerations that guide my work. I do not centre my own experience in this research, but I acknowledge that my positionality inevitably influences my engagement with the topic and the communities involved. I use both person-first and identity-first language as an intentional choice.

As a scholar from the Global North who speaks English as a first language. I recognize that I have benefitted from many privileges, including language, being white and being able-bodied. In my work as a scholar, I seek to elevate and amplify the work of others from equity-deserving groups and to create opportunities for those who have been historically undervalued or marginalized. This is part of my commitment to ethics and integrity in education. I recognize that the perspectives that I bring to my work are both a strength and a limitation.

Background and context

In this section I provide relevant background on academic integrity and highlight current knowledge landscape to set the stage for the findings that follow.

Academic integrity: character, competence, and compliance

Historically, academic integrity has been associated with three overarching themes: character education, academic competence, and rule compliance. Academic integrity scholars who focus on student conduct can be broadly classified into two camps, those who take a moral stance and those believe that academic misconduct is not necessarily a character failing, but rather an educational one (Eaton and Fishman 2024).

Values, morality, and character development have long played a role in education. In the United States, the tradition of honor codes and honor systems have existed for more than two hundred years (Merhar, Fash, and Kuncel 2024). Honor codes have changed over time, ‘from a means for students to defend their reputation, to weeding out unwanted students, to enforcing academic integrity. Today, character development has become a core focus of collegiate honor codes’ (Merhar, Fash, and Kuncel 2024, 39). This historical trajectory suggests that, despite their ethical intent, honor codes can perpetuate exclusionary practices that disproportionately disadvantage disabled or marginalized students under the guise of integrity or quality assurance.

For more than half a century, research on academic misconduct included questions about attitudes towards cheating and perceived seriousness of various types of misconduct including plagiarism, cheating, on exams, and collusion (e.g. Bowers 1966; McCabe 2024). Values such as courage, honesty, fairness, respect, responsibility, and trust having been espoused as fundamental values of academic integrity (International Center for Academic Integrity 2021). Although a values-based framing has shaped the discourse on academic integrity for decades, an emphasis on individual values can be overly simplistic and reductionist, as such an approach can obscure systemic inequities and barriers, and fail to acknowledge broader institutional responsibility to attend to inclusive education and the lived realities of diverse learners. Academic integrity is about more than about individual responsibility; institutions and educational systems – and those who work within them – also bear responsibility for attending to the needs of learners.

Academic misconduct has also been associated with deviance and moral failing (Adam 2024; Beasley 2016). A persistent through line in academic misconduct discourse has been that people who plagiarize or cheat in school are somehow morally corrupt or of undesirable character. This discourse has persisted despite many behaviours reported as cheating can be unintentional, resulting from more from poor academic practice, rather than an intent to deceive (Adam 2024; Jamieson 2024; Pecorari 2023; Seuwou et al. 2023; Stoesz 2024; Thomas and Scott 2016). Some scholars have objected the moralizing of plagiarism and other forms of academic misconduct, calling instead for a stronger focus on developing academic literacy skills, compassion, and dignity (e.g. Eaton 2023; Howard 1992, 1995, 2016; Jamieson 2024; Moya 2024; Pecorari 2023). Reframing misconduct as an academic literacy issue rather than a moral failing can open pathways for supportive responses that prioritize skill development and human dignity.

Historically, rule compliance and strict adherence to policies have been considered an indicator of academic integrity (Eaton 2021; Gagné 2024; Pecorari 2023). Non-compliance with academic rules has long been conflated with violations of academic integrity, potentially putting neurodivergent students at greater risk of being accused of misconduct. I explore this idea further in the sections that follow.

Academic integrity represents the backbone of educational credibility, authenticity, and rigor in higher education. Substantial research on academic integrity practices has examined the relationship between factors such as gender, demographic variables, and institutional processes (Eaton 2021). Educators and scholars have advocated for better academic integrity supports for international students and those who speak English as an additional language (e.g. Dahal and Eaton 2025; Morris and Carroll 2016; Thomas and Scott 2016). Since the mid-2010s, academic integrity discourse has expanded to include consideration of overrepresentation among racialized and visible minority students (e.g. Adam 2024; Beasley 2016; Davis 2022, 2024; Hollis 2024). Despite this progress, the complex interplay between identity, language, and academic integrity remains insufficiently theorized.

Current knowledge landscape and gaps

There has been limited inquiry into the relationship between disability on academic misconduct. Some scholars have extended discourse about ableism and discrimination against persons with disabilities to academic integrity (e.g. Eaton 2023; McDermott 2024). Others have advocated for more inclusive and accessible approaches to learning and assessment design as a way to enact ethics and integrity across the learning ecosystem (e.g. Hallett et al. 2025; Norris, Karasewich, and Kenkel 2024). These contributions highlight a growing recognition of the need to address disability within academic integrity scholarship. Further, little scholarship explores the intersection of academic integrity with neurodiversity. This represents a significant knowledge gap and an urgent need to understand how academic integrity intersects with neurodiversity in higher education settings.

Existing research establishes several important findings about neurodivergent students' experiences in higher education. Clouder et al. (2020) found that neurodivergent students experience higher levels of anxiety, difficulties with time management, and challenges with traditional assessment formats. Many neurodivergent students also face barriers related to disclosure, with fear of stigmatization often preventing them from accessing necessary accommodations (Anderson, Carter, and Stephenson 2018). These findings underscore the need for more inclusive pedagogical approaches and institutional structures that support neurodivergent students' academic success and wellbeing.

Meanwhile, academic integrity scholarship has increasingly focused on inclusive educational practices, contract cheating, and responses to artificial intelligence in academic settings (Eaton 2023). However, these two research streams, neurodiversity and academic integrity, rarely converge in scholarly literature. The intersection of disability and learner differences with academic integrity in general has been neglected (Pagaling, Eaton, and McDermott 2022). In the sections that follow, I outline the findings from a search of the relevant literature.

Conceptual framing: postplagiarism and academic integrity

Postplagiarism constitutes an era where advanced technologies (e.g. artificial intelligence) become normalized in teaching, learning, and communication (Eaton 2021, 2023). Beyond simply challenging plagiarism detection, postplagiarism represents a fundamental shift in our relationship with knowledge creation and attribution.

Postplagiarism defined

Postplagiarism refers to a period in human society where advanced technologies are seamlessly integrated into everyday academic life, one in which technology cannot be decoupled from education (Eaton 2023). Postplagiarism challenges us to reconceptualize academic integrity beyond historical definitions of plagiarism, which focused on stealing others' words and ideas without attribution (Eaton 2023; Kumar 2024, 2025; Muñoz-Cantero and Espiñeira-Bellón 2024).

The concept of postplagiarism builds upon Howard's (2000) assertion that plagiarism is 'inherently indefinable' (p. 473) and extends that thinking to terms such as 'academic integrity' being similarly vague, as well as contextually, culturally, and historically bound (Eaton 2024; Howard 1992, 1995, 2016; Jamieson 2008, 2024). Postplagiarism moves beyond historical notions of academic misconduct being rooted in dishonesty and intention, acknowledging that technology fundamentally transforms how we produce and understand intellectual contributions (Eaton 2023; Kumar 2024, 2025; Muñoz-Cantero and Espiñeira-Bellón 2024).

In a postplagiarism era, hybrid human-AI authorship becomes the norm, rendering detection-based approaches to academic integrity increasingly problematic. Human creativity remains central, potentially enhanced rather than threatened by technological collaboration. Attribution evolves beyond technical requirements to genuine respect for intellectual lineage. Although technology enables new forms of knowledge production, accountability for accuracy and ethical engagement remains with humans. Historical definitions of plagiarism and academic integrity become inadequate, requiring policy adaptations that focus on ethical engagement rather than rule compliance.

Methodology

In this narrative review I explored the literature on neurodivergent students in higher education and their experiences with academic integrity through a transdisciplinary lens. The goal was to examine how neurodiversity intersects with academic integrity policies, practices, and technologies, while considering equity and inclusion.

Rationale for a narrative review

According to Sukhera (2022), 'Narrative reviews are situated within diverse disciplines in the social sciences and humanities. Most forms of narrative reviews align with subjectivist and interpretivist paradigms. These worldviews emphasize that reality is subjective and dynamic. They contrast with the positivist and post-positivist worldviews that are the foundations of systematic reviews: a single reality can be known through experimental research' (p. 414). In contrast, 'narrative reviews allow researchers to describe what is known on a topic while conducting a subjective examination and critique of an entire body of literature. Authors can describe the topic's current status while providing insights on advancing the field, new theories, or current evidence viewed from different or unusual perspectives' (p. 414).

A narrative review method not only aligns with my training as an interpretivist scholar trained in humanities and social sciences, but it also aligns with a neurodiversity

approach, which adopts a social lens on disability and difference, rather than a clinical or medical model (Clouder et al. 2020; Praslova 2024; Shaw et al. 2025).

Methodological process and rigour

This work follows Sukhera's (2022) five foundational elements of narrative reviews: (1) Articulation of a research question; (2) Clarity of scope and definitions of key terms; (3) Justification for inclusion and exclusion criteria; (4) Reflexivity and saturation/sufficiency statement; and (5) Details on analysis and interpretation.

Research questions

Three research questions underpinned this review:

1. How do current academic integrity practices affect neurodivergent students?
2. In what ways do assessment design and institutional policies create barriers to academic success for neurodivergent students?
3. What strategies and approaches might institutions adopt to create more inclusive academic integrity practices?

The findings contribute to emerging discussions on inclusion and academic integrity, suggesting that more inclusive approaches benefit not only neurodivergent students but all members of academic communities.

Scope and definitions

I briefly explored key concepts related academic integrity, misconduct, postplagiarism, and neurodiversity above. Here, I provide some further insights on the framing of the work from a neurodiversity perspective.

I draw from Armstrong's (2012) framing of neurodiversity being a natural variation in human brain function and behavioral traits, acknowledging that cognitive differences are part of human diversity rather than deficits requiring correction. According to some published research, about 1 in 100 children are diagnosed as Autistic (Zeidan et al. 2022) and between 5-10% of the global population has dyslexia (Knight 2018), but we know that such numbers do not tell the whole story, with underdiagnosis being among the complexities that lead to incomplete information about the prevalence of neurodivergence (see, for example, O'Nions et al. 2023). These statistics suggest a significant proportion of higher education students may be neurodivergent, though exact numbers remain difficult to determine due to underdiagnosis as well as disclosure concerns.

Search method, inclusion and exclusion criteria

I conducted a comprehensive search of academic databases including ERIC, EBSCO Education Research Complete, Scopus, and Web of Science, using search terms in two categories (1) neurodiversity and (2) academic integrity (see Table 1). Sources had to include search terms from both categories in the title and/or abstract and/or main text.

Table 1. Search terms.

Category 1: Search terms related to neurodiversity	Category 2: Search terms related to academic integrity
Neurodivergent OR neurodiversity OR ADHD OR autism OR autistic OR dyslexia OR dyscalculia OR dyspraxia	'academic integrity' OR 'academic misconduct' OR 'academic honesty' OR 'academic dishonesty' OR cheating OR plagiarism

The search focused on English-language peer-reviewed publications from 2000 (January 1) to 2025 (July 31) to capture contemporary perspectives while acknowledging rapid technological changes in higher education. Sources were included if full-texts were available and were written in English. To ensure comprehensive coverage, I implemented a forwards and backwards citation search on key papers and supplemented with articles and reports already known to me (i.e. seed articles). Following Bonato’s (2018) guidance on including grey literature if it fills knowledge gaps, originates from a trusted source, answers the research question, and includes credible references, types of grey literature considered for inclusion were academic blog posts, book chapters, conference presentations and proceedings, and reports. Sources were excluded if they were not written in English or were published in 1999 or earlier.

Analysis method

I followed Sukhera’s method for an integrative narrative review, drawing on manual qualitative coding methods (Saldaña 2021). Each text was read in detail to find patterns and themes across sources. This was complemented by techniques commonly used in other types of systematic and scoping reviews (Thomas and Harden 2008), such as data extraction to determine study type and other relevant details.

Reflexivity and saturation

Sukhera (2022) notes that authors should engage in a reflexive process that includes acknowledging factors that shaped interpretation and analysis, which I did in my positionality statement above. I have delimited this review to the specific topic of the intersection academic integrity and neurodivergence and recognize that there is extensive literature on both topics that extend beyond the scope of this review.

Analysis and interpretation

The study began with a set of seven seed articles, defined by MacDonald and Young (2024) as sources that ‘can help identify search terms and ensure the search strategy finds relevant studies’ (p. 1). Database searches produced a total of 83 results (see Table 2). Following de-duplication of results, a preliminary screening of titles and abstracts was performed. Sources which clearly did not address the research question were eliminated at this stage. Of those that remained, a review of the full text of the source was performed. Those that addressed the research question were included. Finally, results were de-duplicated, resulting in a sub-total of ten sources included in the review from the database search. These were cross-referenced with the seed articles. Three of the seven seed articles appeared in the database search results (Kinder and Elander 2012; Pagaling, Eaton, and McDermott 2022; Price 2006).

Table 2. Database search results.

Database	Number of Results
EBSCO Education Research Complete	30
ERIC (US Dept. of Education)	20
Scopus	2
Web of Science	31
Total	83

Four seed articles that did not appear in the database results were grey literature including two book chapters (Gagné 2024; Gegg-Harrison and Quarterman 2024), one conference presentation (Gegg-Harrison 2024), and one blog post (2023). It was notable that the seed sources that did not appear in the database results were authored by individuals who explicitly self-identified as neurodivergent in the sources selected for inclusion. Due to a combination of academic expertise and lived experience with neurodivergence, the seed sources were retained in the results. A total of 15 sources were included in the final analysis (See Figure 1).

Study types

Of the 15 sources selected for analysis there were two quantitative studies (15%); three qualitative studies (20%); two mixed methods studies (15%); one review article (7%); and five conceptual/theoretical essays (33%) (rounded to the nearest whole number). (See Table 3).

Representation and sample sizes

Of the nine studies that included human participants, none had sample sizes that could be considered representative of a total population. Even the Anderman et al. (2022) study with 855 students, which was the largest sample size of any of the studies, drew

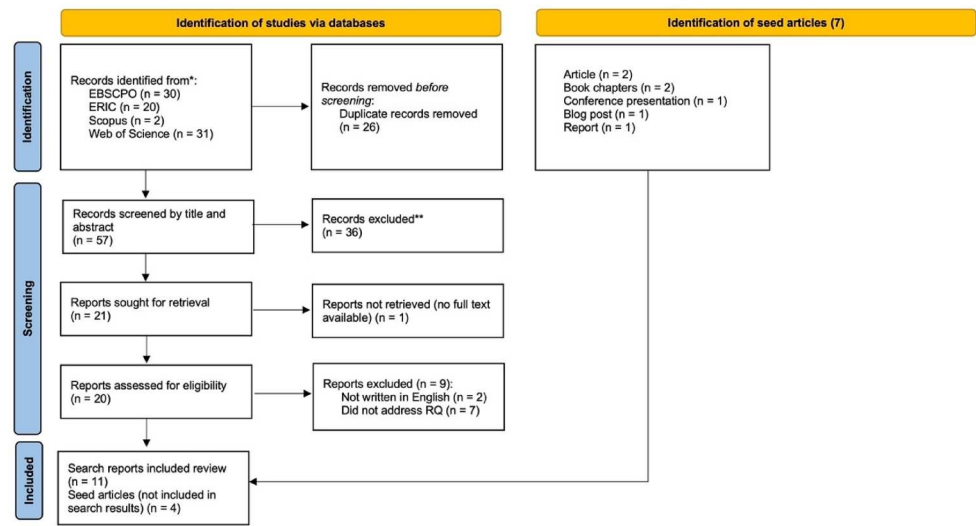


Figure 1. Flow diagram of search and screening process.

Table 3. Summary of results.

#	Source	Source type	Methodology	Sample size (n =)	Seed article	Search results	Author(s) Country Affiliations
1	Anderman, E. M., Gilman, R., Liu, X., & Ha, S. Y. (2022).	Article	Quantitative	855	No	Yes	USA
2	Author (2023).	Article	Conceptual	N/A	No	Yes	Canada
3	Author (2024).	Article	Conceptual	N/A	No	Yes	Canada
4	Gagné, A. (2024).	Book chapter	Conceptual	N/A	Yes	No	Canada
5	Gegg-Harrison, W. (2023, February 27).	Blog post	Conceptual	N/A	Yes	No	USA
6	Gegg-Harrison, W. (2024).	Conference presentation	Qualitative	5	Yes	No	USA
7	Gegg-Harrison, W., & Quarterman, C. (2024).	Book chapter	Qualitative	5	Yes	No	USA
8	Kinder, J., & Elander, J. (2012).	Article	Mixed Methods	62	Yes	Yes	UK
9	MacCullagh, L., Bosanquet, A., & Badcock, N. A. (2017).	Article	Mixed Methods	27	No	No	Australia
10	McDermott, G., & O'Donoghue, C. (2024).	Article	Conceptual	N/A	No	Yes	Ireland
11	Author. (2022).	Report	Review	N/A	Yes	Yes	Canada
12	Price, G. A. (2006).	Article	Mixed Methods	3	Yes	Yes	UK
13	Shaw, S. C. K., Hennessy, L. R., & Anderson, J. L. (2022).	Article	Qualitative	5	No	Yes	UK
14	Sideridis, G. D., & Stamovlasis, D. (2014).	Article	Experimental	32	No	Yes	USA and Greece
15	Zhao, X., Cox, A., & Chen, X. (2025).	Article	Quantitative	124	No	Yes	UK

participants from three public high schools (presumably in the United States, since this was where the authors self-identified as being from). There was no information provided about the total number of high school students in the state(s) where data were collected and no details provided about how representative the sample size was of the total number of secondary students in the country at the time of data collection.

The results show that the experiences of neurodivergent individuals with regards to academic cheating are understudied. In addition, available results are not representative of the total number of student populations, nor of individuals with Autism, ADHD, dyslexia or other conditions that could be classified under an umbrella of neurodivergence.

Authors' institutional affiliations showed representation from the USA, Canada, UK, Greece, and Australia, though it should be noted that institutional and country representation may not necessarily reflect authors' country of origin. The country representation is nevertheless relevant as it shows that all studies that met the inclusion criteria were from English-speaking, European heritage countries. There was a complete lack of representation from authors affiliated with institutions in Latin America, Asia or Africa. A discussion about why this occurred would be speculative at best, but suffice to say that there is room for voices from beyond Anglo-European contexts to be heard in broader discussions about neurodiversity, academic integrity and student success.

Narrative analysis

Three overarching themes emerged from the narrative analysis: (1) The intersectional challenges of academic integrity and disability/neurodivergence; (2) the dual nature of educational technology: aid for accessibility versus a source of academic misconduct risk; and (3) The imperative for human-centred, trust-based, and accessible pedagogical practices. I elaborate on each theme below.

Theme 1: the intersectional challenges of academic integrity and disability/neurodivergence

Students with disabilities and neurodivergent conditions face specific academic challenges that intersect with, and are often misunderstood by, traditional academic integrity frameworks. One recurrent theme was the impact of disability and neurodivergence on academic tasks. Students with conditions such as ADHD, dyslexia, dyspraxia, and Autism frequently reported difficulties with academic writing, including proofreading, reading comprehension, structuring ideas, maintaining concentration, managing time, and overcoming mental blocks (MacCullagh, Bosanquet, and Badcock 2017; Price 2006; Zhao, Cox, and Chen 2025).

These challenges can lead to feelings of struggle and being overwhelmed (Gegg-Harrison and Quarterman 2024; Zhao, Cox, and Chen 2025). For instance, dyslexic students often exhibit lower confidence in writing and understanding of authorship, and their difficulties with transcription and spelling can consume cognitive resources needed for higher-level writing (Kinder and Elander 2012; Shaw, Hennessy, and Anderson 2022). The discourse around academic integrity often questions the legitimacy of academic accommodations, sometimes framing extra time on exams or the use of assistive technology as ‘sanctioned cheating’ (Gagné 2024, 1255). Viewing accommodations as a form of sanctioned misconduct overlooks the fundamental need for equitable treatment to level the playing field for disabled learners.

Two studies suggested a relationship between executive functioning problems and academic cheating (Anderman et al. 2022; Sideridis and Stamovlasis 2014). One study suggested a relationship between executive functioning problems (EFP), including inattention and hyperactivity, and academic cheating in adolescents (Anderman et al. 2022). Neither study discussed pedagogical interventions or student support that could help students who struggle with executive functioning and instead adopted a deficit-based perspective, with one study claiming that students with learning disabilities (LD) were prone to learned helplessness (Sideridis and Stamovlasis 2014), but made no mention of how educators or others could actually support LD students.

Theme 2: the dual nature of educational technology: aid for accessibility vs. Source of academic misconduct risk

Advanced technologies, particularly artificial intelligence (AI) and proctoring software, present both opportunities to enhance accessibility for neurodivergent learners and can also put those same students at risk of breaching academic integrity. Generative AI can be used as an assistive tool to promote learning among neurodivergent and disabled

students. Generative AI tools such as ChatGPT, Grammarly, and DeepL are widely used by students with disabilities to summarise reading materials, overcome mental blocks, brainstorm ideas, structure assignments, rewrite phrases, and refine written work (Zhao, Cox, and Chen 2025). These tools can make complex topics more understandable, help identify learning resources, and reduce anxiety associated with challenging academic tasks, though they are not perfect and students need to be supported to learn how to use them well. Some argue that technology, including AI can level the playing field for students with dyslexia, ADD, ADHD, and autism by supporting multiple means of representation and action (Eaton 2023; Gagné 2024; MacCullagh, Bosanquet, and Badcock 2017; McDermott and O'Donoghue 2024; Zhao, Cox, and Chen 2025). Generative AI has the potential to foster equity and accessibility for neurodivergent learners, though its use must be accompanied by thoughtful guidance to mitigate risks and maximize benefits.

However, it is not all good news when it comes to the use of AI. The inaccuracy of AI detection tools and their inherent bias against particular demographic groups, in particular Autistic people, was repeated in the literature. Despite claims of high accuracy, AI detection tools are unreliable and prone to false positives (Gegg-Harrison 2023, 2024; Gegg-Harrison and Quarterman 2024). These tools often rely on statistical 'signatures' such as perplexity and burstiness, which are unreliable indicators of human-generated text. False positives are not randomly distributed and disproportionately affect non-native English writers and neurodivergent individuals (e.g. those with ADHD/AuDHD), leading to psychological and material harm for falsely accused students (Gegg-Harrison 2023). Reliance on flawed AI detection systems not only undermines fairness but can also amplify harm for already marginalized student populations, meaning that anti-cheating technologies may exacerbate existing inequities.

A recurring theme through the literature was caution against e-proctoring and surveillance technologies. Remote proctoring software is described as inherently ableist, interfering with assistive devices and accessibility tools (Gagné 2024). These technologies are seen as so-called solutions to misconduct, but these same tools can be incongruous with accessibility and perpetuate a lack of trust. There has been a call to limit the use of surveillance technologies in online learning environments and offer alternative examination methods (Eaton 2024; Gagné 2024; Gegg-Harrison 2023; Gegg-Harrison and Quarterman 2024; Pagaling, Eaton, and McDermott 2022). The literature underscores that surveillance-based proctoring erodes trust and accessibility, reinforcing calls for inclusive assessment practices over punitive monitoring.

Theme 3: the imperative for human-centred, trust-based, and accessible pedagogical practices

Researchers advocate for a fundamental shift in educational philosophy, moving away from punitive, competition-driven approaches towards a focus on human rights, dignity, and inclusive pedagogy (Eaton 2023, 2024; Gagné 2024). Sources included a critique of traditional assessment and a trust deficit with students. Current assessment practices in higher education are often deeply rooted in competition, which can be incompatible with accessibility goals and foster a lack of trust (Gagné 2024; Shaw, Hennessy, and Anderson 2022; Sideridis and Stamovlasis 2014). A competitive environment

can lead to skepticism about the authorship of work by disabled students using assistive technology, which can further perpetuate discrimination against already marginalized individuals (Gagné 2024; Kinder and Elander 2012; Zhao, Cox, and Chen 2025). Academic integrity discussions are frequently top-down and focus on punishment rather than prevention or support.

In addition, there is a strong call to prioritise human rights, dignity, and non-discrimination in the development and implementation of misconduct policies and procedures. This approach emphasizes compassion over callousness and *equitable* treatment over merely *equal* treatment, recognising diverse backgrounds and needs, such as those of first-generation or international students (Eaton 2024; Gagné 2024; Gegg-Harrison and Quarterman 2024; Pagaling, Eaton, and McDermott 2022; Shaw, Hennessy, and Anderson 2022, Zhao, Cox, and Chen 2025). This perspective reinforces the need for misconduct policies grounded in empathy and equity, ensuring that diverse student identities are respected and human dignity remains central.

Researchers called for the implementation of accessible pedagogy and inclusive assessment. Recommendations include reviewing assessment design and pedagogy to be accessible, utilising Universal Design for Learning (UDL) principles (Eaton 2024; Gagné 2024; McDermott and O'Donoghue 2024; Pagaling, Eaton, and McDermott 2022). This means offering multiple means of action and expression for learning, fostering trust in educational spaces to avoid forced disclosures, moving away from reliance on technological services like proctoring, and centering learning alongside others rather than in isolation. Ethical assessment should also include developing and presenting learning materials in ways that empower students to learn and shift focus from preventing misconduct to supporting student success.

Discussion

In this section I discuss the findings of this review in relation to the broader literature and a conceptual framing of postplagiarism.

Students' underperformance in assessment has long been conflated with deficiency on the part of the student (Tai et al. 2022) In an era where AI-generated content becomes ubiquitous, questions arise about how to design assessments that remain accessible to neurodivergent students while maintaining academic integrity. One current knowledge gap includes understanding how Universal Design for Learning (UDL) principles can be integrated with academic integrity practices in ways that benefit neurodivergent students.

Current assessment practices in higher education remain largely rooted in what Gagné (2024) terms the 'cult of competition' (p. 1252). This competitive framing is 'fundamentally at odds with accessibility' (p. 1252) and creates conditions that disadvantage neurodivergent students. Text-heavy timed examinations, synchronous assessment formats, and rigid submission requirements can all create unintended barriers. Furthermore, there is a lack of data about whether certain assessment formats create higher risk of misconduct for neurodivergent students. For example, does the cognitive load of navigating complex written instructions increase the likelihood that a student with ADHD might unintentionally omit citations? Currently, there is insufficient evidence to be able to answer such questions.

An additional contribution to current thinking around academic integrity takes the focus off student behaviour and places it instead on educators who bear the responsibility for assessment validity and security (Dawson 2021; 2022; Eaton 2023). Assessment security has to do with detecting and deterring cheating through assessment design and the manner in which assessments (e.g. exams) are administered (Dawson 2022). Examples of assessment security include invigilating exams and using text-matching software (e.g. Turnitin) to identify possible breaches of integrity (Dawson 2021). This shift reframes academic integrity as a shared responsibility, emphasizing that robust assessment design and security measures are essential for maintaining validity and fairness.

When designing assessments, it is incumbent upon educators to consider the needs of all learners, including neurodivergent students who may face unique challenges in traditional assessment formats. Clouder et al. (2020) highlight that neurodivergent students experience anxiety and stress when confronted with assessment tasks that do not accommodate their learning differences. However, neurodivergent and disabled students might conceal their challenges due to fear of stigmatization, creating a gap between available support services and those who need them.

Artificial intelligence, academic integrity and neurodivergent students

Neurodivergent students may use AI-tools more than neurotypical students (Fletcher et al. 2024; Zhao, Cox, and Chen 2025). A full exploration of the promises and perils of AI-assistance for neurodivergent students is beyond the scope of this study, but one noteworthy topic emerged in the literature: the use of tools that can allegedly detect the use of AI-generated text. The use of AI text-detection tools has been identified as being problematic for a number of reasons (Kumar 2024; Perkins et al. 2024). Neurodivergent researcher, Gegg-Harrison, has studied and problematized the use of AI text-detection tools on individuals with Autism or combined Autism and ADHD (AuDHD) (Gegg-Harrison 2023, 2024; Gegg-Harrison and Quarterman 2024). Gegg-Harrison and Quarterman (2024) found that neurodivergent students may be at a higher risk of false positive results AI text-detection tools. Although their study was small scale and further study is needed, initial findings signalled that neurodivergent students may be negatively impacted by software designed and marketed to detect writing done by AI apps. A false positive result from an AI text-detection tool can result in unsubstantiated allegations of academic misconduct against students. Gegg-Harrison and Quarterman (2024) conclude that the use of AI text-detection tools is unethical, in part, because they exacerbate ‘the likelihood of a disproportionate impact on students who already face marginalization’ (p. 199). These findings highlight an urgent need for institutional policies and further research to ensure that AI text-detection tools do not perpetuate inequities or disproportionately penalize neurodivergent students.

Academic integrity, ableism, and postplagiarism

Current academic integrity policies and procedures often reflect ableist assumptions (Gagné 2024). For example, timed, high-stakes examinations and rigid formatting requirements may disadvantage neurodivergent students. Teaching, learning, and assessing in a post-plagiarism era requires assessment design that prioritizes authentic

learning, supports diverse learners, and reduces incentives for academic misconduct. By moving beyond detection-focused approaches toward assessment that values process, personalization, and the application of knowledge, educators can create learning environments where academic integrity emerges from engagement rather than enforcement. This shift not only addresses the challenges posed by AI tools but also creates more inclusive, equitable learning experiences for all students, particularly those who are neurodivergent or face other barriers in traditional assessment formats.

Understanding academic integrity as epistemic plurality

Academic integrity is about more than adherence to citation rules or avoidance of plagiarism; it represents a complex intersection of diverse knowledge systems, cognitive processes, and educational policies and practices. The concept of epistemic plurality offers a valuable framework for reconceptualizing academic integrity beyond punitive approaches toward a more inclusive understanding that acknowledges different ways of knowing.

When we examine academic integrity through an epistemic plurality lens, we recognize that knowledge production varies across disciplines, cultures, and cognitive styles. This perspective is particularly important when considering neurodivergent students, who may process and express knowledge differently than neurotypical peers. Neurodivergent students' writing exhibits discernible differences in syntactic features and lexical choices, suggesting different approaches to knowledge organization and expression (De Bruyne, Verhoeven, and Daelemans 2018). Rather than interpreting these differences as deficiencies, educators might better serve students by recognizing these differences as alternative epistemic expressions.

This recognition connects to the broader issue of assessment design. Competitive, high-stakes assessment designs may inherently disadvantage neurodivergent students and in doing so, create conditions where academic misconduct becomes more likely (Gagné 2024). The prevailing emphasis on standardized assessment reflects what might be termed epistemic privilege, or an unquestioned acceptance of dominant knowledge systems while marginalizing other ways of knowing. When we design assessments with epistemic plurality in mind, we might not only reduce barriers for neurodivergent students but also, potentially decrease instances of academic misconduct born from inaccessible educational structures.

Clouder et al. (2020) noted that 'neurodiversity "cold spots" despite the existence of support services' (p. 775) persist in higher education due to 'dislocation maintained by low levels of staff awareness, ambivalence and inflexible teaching and assessment approaches' (p. 775). This observation highlights how institutional structures often fail to accommodate epistemic plurality, instead requiring students to conform to dominant knowledge systems regardless of cognitive fit. The resulting tension creates what Price (2006) describes as situations where students must negotiate complex trade-offs between academic success and authentic knowledge expression.

A more productive approach would recognize academic integrity as fundamentally connected to epistemic diversity. Such a perspective shifts our understanding from a binary view of integrity versus misconduct toward a more nuanced recognition of how different knowledge systems and epistemic plurality interact with institutional

expectations. Macfarlane (2021) advocates for accommodation processes that accept individuals' self-assessments rather than requiring extensive documentation – a model that could extend to academic integrity practices that prioritize epistemic inclusion over standardization. Understanding academic integrity through a lens of epistemic plurality provides a social justice basis for supporting student success that aligns with critical pedagogy (Dawson 2024; Steinberg 2021). Education should be about empowering students to live in a world where they can 'interrogate the nature of power within a societal situation' (Steinberg 2021, 125). The knowledge, skills, and confidence to engage in such interrogation of a society can only happen if students are treated as whole and complete human beings who already have integrity, rather than as deficient creatures who need to be fixed, surveilled or punished for the very differences that make them who they are.

Moving forward, institutions could develop epistemically pluralistic approaches to academic integrity. These would include universal design principles in assessment, flexibility in knowledge expression, and explicit recognition of diverse cognitive styles in academic policy. Such approaches would frame academic integrity less as compliance with standardized practices and more as authentic engagement with knowledge creation that respects diverse ways of knowing. By reframing academic integrity through epistemic plurality and a postplagiarism lens, we can develop more inclusive practices that accommodate neurodivergent students while maintaining meaningful educational standards. This shift would move beyond the current emphasis on detection and punishment toward a more holistic understanding of knowledge creation and expression.

Directions for future work

The findings from this review show specific areas for development (1) a need for larger-scale and more representative studies; (2) a need for research from beyond Anglo-European contexts; and (3) the inclusion of neurodivergent students as co-researchers and co-authors.

Until research findings are representative of students with disabilities and differences that set them apart from their neurotypical peers, their needs will not be understood or adequately resourced. Funding and resource decisions are often made on the basis of evidence, and an absence of evidence can result in perpetual neglect of an already marginalised student population.

Secondly, the results of this review showed an overwhelming dominance of contributions from researchers with affiliations from Anglo-European contexts, but we know that disabilities and differences affect people all over the world. There is an urgent need for research, especially empirical studies, on the intersection of neurodivergence and student success in general, and specifically on topics related to academic integrity.

Finally, in the spirit of 'nothing about us without us' (Charlton 1998), individuals with disabilities and differences must be included in research about them, as well as in decisions made about them. This includes increasing personal involvement, cultivating theoretical awareness, and having our voices elevated and amplified. Given that policy and practices decisions related to allegations of academic integrity breaches can have long-standing implications for any student, it is even more important that academic decisions about disabled and neurodivergent students are influenced and informed by individuals with lived experience.

Limitations

This review is necessarily limited by the available published literature, which often foregrounds certain neurodivergent conditions (e.g. dyslexia, ADHD, and Autism) over others. Additionally, although efforts were made to include diverse perspectives, the findings reflect the dominance of the Global North in this area of research. This review has focused on English-language publications, and it is worth noting that research in additional languages could further enrich our understandings of the topics presented herein.

Conclusion

In this review I examined how neurodiversity impacts academic writing and institutional support for neurodiverse students. Although technological support has expanded, significant gaps remain between available resources and student experience, creating a paradox of support without accessibility in higher education. The results show a persistent disconnect between technological and educational advancements and their practical application for neurodivergent students, underscoring systemic barriers that remain despite progress.

Supporting neurodivergent students requires moving beyond deficit models toward recognizing neurodiversity as human variation that enriches academic communities. Institutions must embed neurodiversity principles into curriculum design, faculty development, and academic integrity policies and procedures to ensure inclusion is not aspirational, but operational. Ultimately, academic integrity can only exist when we account for equity, diversity, inclusion, and accessibility; otherwise, we risk performative academic integrity theatre. By reimagining academic integrity through a neurodiversity lens rather than as rule-compliance, institutions can create environments where all students feel safe and supported in their learning and can excel while being true to who they are.

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